

Dear Matafele Peinam

for soprano and piano

Clifton Callender

Kathy Jetñil-Kijiner, text

2021

Dear Matafele Peinam

1. You are
2. I want to tell you
3. Don't cry
4. You'll see

for William and Ethan
we will all fight

Written for Phyllis Pancella

Duration: ca. 18 minutes

PROGRAM NOTES

[N]ow that I feel personally and intimately anchored in the future in a different way, I feel a different kind of fear. — Jedediah Britton-Purdy

[M]y work has [...] always been about processing the emotional weight of climate change through art.¹ — Kathy Jetñil-Kijiner

Several years ago, I fell into despair after hearing a report about millennials questioning the wisdom, even morality, of having children given the climate crisis and projections of the type of world their children would inherit. Setting aside the merits of such arguments², the discussion struck at the heart of my own anxieties raising two children who are aware that their entire lives will be affected unpredictably by climate change. Succumbing to these fears, I was plagued with insomnia, joyless, and felt physically ill at my own daily contributions to greenhouse gas emissions.

Looking beyond scientific articles and the news, I turned to artistic responses to the crisis and discovered the work of the Marshall Islander poet, spoken-word artist, and climate activist Kathy Jetñil-Kijiner. “Dear Matafele Peinam” was written for and first performed at the Opening Ceremony of the 2014 UN Secretary-General’s Climate Summit. Written to her then seven-month-old daughter, the poem addresses climate change in general and the specific and urgent threat to the Marshall Islands and similar island countries through the lens of the most intimate of relationships—a parent seeking to protect their child.

we are artists painting, dancing, writing

In setting the poem, I've done my best to capture its meaning and provide a musical context for the text without losing the overall directness, succinct articulation of the threat and subsequent focus on the collective fight, and especially the touching depiction of the poet's daughter. The poem is presented in four sections, realized as four separate movements. "You are" captures the simple delights of a young child (bananas, hugs, walks by the lagoon) and concludes with a slightly exhausted mother and a still bouncing baby. "I want to tell you" hints at the threats facing the Marshall Islands, with peaceful lagoons devouring shorelines, sea walls, and roots of breadfruit trees, rendering the islands uninhabitable, their inhabitants left to wander without a home. The third and by far largest section of the poem ("Don't cry") channels anger at "blindfolded bureaucracies" and companies "with broken morals" into personal and collective action. "You'll see" is (mostly) a lullaby, reassuring a drowsy child and recalling the melody from the first movement most associated with her.

i apologize to you

The most challenging portion of the text to set was a passage in the third movement in which Jetñil-Kijiner changes voice, directly apologizing to other Pacific Islanders who have already become climate-change refugees. At this point, the music is suddenly torn off and the text is framed by a strident chord. This same chord recurs in three separate passages: the first recurrence accompanies lines about those who pretend that the Marshall Islands and similar island nations, as well as the many disasters attributed to climate change, don't exist. The chord next accompanies text about people marching in the streets "chanting for change NOW." Finally, this chord associated with apology slightly colors the closing repeated chords recalling the bouncing baby from the opening movement.

Since the poem was completed in 2014, there have been many other climate-change disasters and refugees—devastating cyclones striking southern Africa and Puerto Rico, wildfires in Australia and California, massive floods in south Asia, severe droughts in east Africa and central America, European heatwaves. Indeed, Marshall Islanders are having to contemplate raising their islands or the construction of artificial islands in case it becomes impossible to remain on their homeland in its natural state. Will we have to apologize to this daughter? To our own children?

we won't let you down, you'll see

We can't promise our children that everything will be okay, but we can assure them that we are going to fight, which begins with those most vulnerable to climate change. The best chance we have to protect our own homeland is to do everything we can to preserve theirs.

¹ Jetñil-Kijiner, K. (2019, February 19). Bulldozed reefs and blasted sands: rituals for artificial islands [Blog post]. Retrieved from <http://kathyjetnilkijiner.com/blog/>.

² Gibson, C. (2020, February 14). How climate experts think about raising children who will inherit a planet in crisis. *Washington Post*. Retrieved from <http://washingtonpost.com>.

TEXT

"Dear Matafele Peinam" by Kathy Jetñil-Kijiner
from lep Jāltok: Poems from a Marshallese Daughter

dear matafele peinam,

you are a seven month old sunrise of gummy smiles
you are bald as an egg and bald as the buddha
you are thighs that are thunder and shrieks that are lightning
so excited for bananas, hugs and
our morning walks past the lagoon

dear matafele peinam,

i want to tell you about that lagoon
that lucid, sleepy lagoon lounging against the sunrise

men say that one day
that lagoon will devour you

they say it will gnaw at the shoreline
chew at the roots of your breadfruit trees
gulp down rows of your seawalls
and crunch your island's shattered bones

they say you, your daughter
and your granddaughter, too
will wander rootless
with only a passport to call home

dear matafele peinam,

don't cry

mommy promises you

no one
will come and devour you

no greedy whale of a company sharking through political seas
no backwater bullying of businesses with broken morals
no blindfolded bureaucracies gonna push
this mother ocean over
the edge

no one's drowning, baby
no one's moving

no one's losing
their homeland
no one's gonna become
a climate change refugee

or should i say
no one else

to the carteret islanders of papua new guinea
and to the taro islanders of the solomon islands
i take this moment
to apologize to you
we are drawing the line here

because baby we are going to fight
your mommy daddy
bubu jimma your country and president too
we will all fight

and even though there are those
hidden behind platinum titles
who like to pretend
that we don't exist
that the marshall islands
tuvalu
kiribati
maldives
and typhoon haiyan in the philippines
and floods of pakistan, algeria, colombia
and all the hurricanes, earthquakes, and tidalwaves
didn't exist

still
there are those
who see us

hands reaching out
fists raising up
banners unfurling
megaphones booming
and we are
canoes blocking coal ships
we are
the radiance of solar villages
we are
the rich clean soil of the farmer's past
we are
petitions blooming from teenage fingertips
we are

families biking, recycling, reusing,
engineers dreaming, designing, building,
artists painting, dancing, writing
and we are spreading the word

and there are thousands out on the street
marching with signs
hand in hand
chanting for change NOW

and they're marching for you, baby
they're marching for us

because we deserve to do more than just
survive
we deserve
to thrive

dear matafele peinam,

you are eyes heavy
with drowsy weight
so just close those eyes, baby
and sleep in peace

because we won't let you down
you'll see

Dear Matafele Peinam

Kathy Jetnil-Kijiner

Clifton Callender

1. You are

Scherzando ♩ = 138

Piano

f *p* *8va* "music box" *8va* *p*

Red.

Pno

(8)

Pno

(8)

A

mf *Sost.* 3 3 3 3 3

Pno

10 3 5 3 3 3 3 3

B

f *ff* *Sost.* *Red.*

You are

♪ = ♩ sempre (unless
indicated otherwise)

14

S. *mf*

you are

"music box"

Pno *p* *8va* *f* *p*

mp (Led.) Sost. *mp*

19

S. a se - ven month old sun - rise

Pno (Sost.)

23

S. of gum - my ha smiles

Pno *mp* *mf*

Sost. (Led.)

[illegible]

Musical score for Piano (Pno). The score is written for two staves (treble and bass clef). It begins with a treble clef and a key signature of one flat (B-flat). The tempo is marked 'Andante' (And.). The score is divided into measures by bar lines. The first measure is marked with a '3' and a '3', indicating a triplet. The second measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The third measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The fourth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The fifth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The sixth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The seventh measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The eighth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The ninth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The tenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The eleventh measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The twelfth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The thirteenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The fourteenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The fifteenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The sixteenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The seventeenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The eighteenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The nineteenth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The twentieth measure is marked with a '3' and a '3'. The score ends with a double bar line.

37

Pno

ff

p

8va

(Red.)

Red.

41

Pno

pp

ff

mf *ff* *mf*

D

(Red.)

47

ff *mf* *ff* *mf* *ff* *mf* *ff* *mf* *ff* *mf* *ff* *mf*

You are

Pno

52

E *mf*

S. you are

Pno

ff *mf* *p* *ff* *mp* *mf*

Red. *Sost.*

56

S. bald as an egg bald

"music box"

Pno

mf *mp*

60

S.

as the bud dha bud - dha

Pno

63

S.

bud - - - - - dha

(staccato)

8va

Pno

3

3

p

Sost.

66

Pno

8va

F

$\text{♩} = 108$

p

mp

Red.

(Sost.)

70 *mf*

S. *you are thighs*

Pno *p*

(Sost.) *(mp)*

73

S. *that are thun - der you are*

Pno *8va*

(Sost.)

76

S. *shrieks that are light*

Pno *8va*

(Sost.)

90

S. *for ba - na - nas na - nas na - na - na - na -*

Pno

94 **H** $\text{♩} = \text{♩}$

S. *- na - na - na - nas ba - na - na - na - na - na - na - nas*

Pno

99 **I** $\text{♩} = 108$

S. *hugs hugs hugs hugs hugs hugs hugs*

Pno

102

S. *hugs hugs_ hugs hu - hu - hu - hu - hugs*

Pno

(♩ = 144)

♩ = ♩

J

105 *mp* *mf*

S. *and our_ morn - ing walks past the_ la - - goon_ la - -*

Pno *mp* *mf*

Red.

109

S. *- goon_ la - - goon_ la - - goon*

Pno

(*Red.*)

Red.

114

S. *la - - - goon la la la la la la*

Pno

Red.

117 **K**

S. *la thun - - -*

Pno

ff (very heavy accents)

8va

120

S. *-der light - - - ning you are*

Pno

f (normal accents)

mf

mp

125

S. 

you are you are you are

Pno 

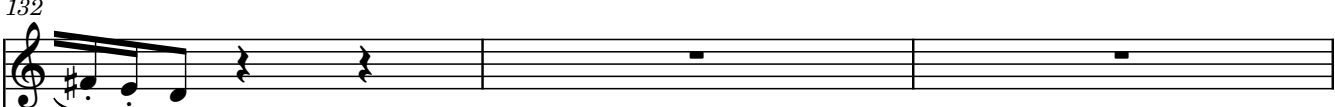
129

S. 

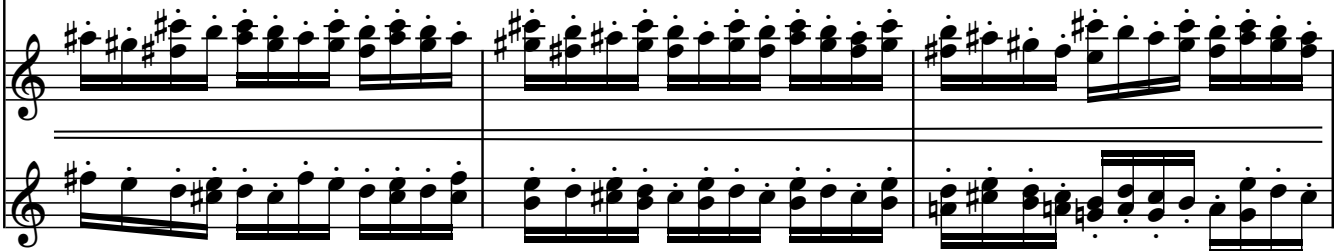
you are you are you are you

Pno 

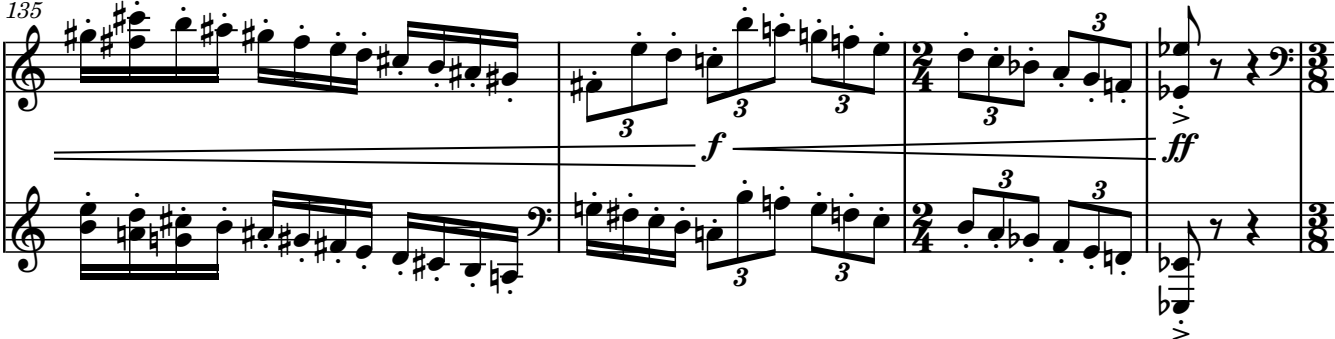
132

S. 

are

Pno 

135

Pno 

f *ff*

139 **L**

S. (exhausted)

you are

Pno

mf *p*

gliss.

220.

143

Pno

Largo ♩ = 56 *mp*

Soprano

I want to tell you a - bout that la - goon

f *p*

8va

Piano

p *Red.* *simile*

5

S.

that lu - cid slee - py la - goon

Pno

8 **A**

S.

loun - g a - gainst the sun - rise

f *p* *mf*

8va

Pno

(p)

11 *mp* *f*

S. *3* *3* *3* *3*

men say that one day that la - goon will de - vour you

Pno

14 **B** *mf*

S. *3*

they say it will gnaw

Pno *f* *p* *8va* *3* *3* *3*

17 *p* *3*

S. *3* *3*

at the shore - line chew

Pno

19 *mf* **C** *f*

S. at the roots of your bread - fruit trees

Pno *ff* *p* 8va

21 *p* *f*

S. gulp down rows of your

Pno

24 *mf* (*f*) *mf* *mp*

S. sea - walls and crunch your is - lands shat - tered

Pno 8ba

27 D

S. *bones*

Pno *pp* *cresc.*

(8) *ℓeo.*

32

Pno *ℓeo.* E ♩ = 70

38

Pno *p cresc.* *p*

43

Pno *mp cresc.*

(8) *ℓeo.*

The musical score is for a song titled "I want to tell you". It features a vocal line (S.) and a piano accompaniment (Pno). The score is divided into four systems, each marked with a double bar line and a repeat sign. The first system starts at measure 27 with a vocal line and a piano accompaniment. The vocal line has a long note on "bones" that spans across measures. The piano accompaniment has a bass line with a triplet of eighth notes. The second system starts at measure 32 and includes a key signature change to E major, indicated by a box with the letter "E". The third system starts at measure 38 and the fourth at measure 43. The piano accompaniment features various textures, including chords, arpeggios, and triplets. Dynamics include piano (pp), mezzo-piano (mp), and crescendo (cresc.). The tempo is marked as ♩ = 70. The score includes a key signature change to E major and a time signature change from 3/4 to 2/4.

Piano score for measures 47-50. The score is for Piano (Pno) and includes a vocal line (8va) starting at measure 48. The key signature is one sharp (F#). The time signature is 3/4. The score includes triplets and a crescendo marking (*mf cresc.*). The first system ends with a repeat sign.

47
Pno
(8va.)
mf cresc.

Piano score for measures 51-55. The score is for Piano (Pno) and includes a vocal line (8va) starting at measure 52. The key signature is one sharp (F#). The time signature is 3/4. The score includes triplets and a crescendo marking (*f cresc.*). The first system ends with a repeat sign.

51
Pno
(8va.)
f cresc.

Piano score for measures 56-60. The score is for Piano (Pno) and includes a vocal line (8va) starting at measure 57. The key signature is one sharp (F#). The time signature is 3/4. The score includes triplets, a quintuplet, and a crescendo marking (*f cresc.*). The first system ends with a repeat sign.

56
Pno
(8va.)
f cresc.

gradually accelerate 16th
notes in right hand

Pno

60

(Red.)

Pno

63

ff

pp

fff

f possibile

f possibile

(Red.)

(Red.)

(Red.)

(Red.)

Pno

68

sempre f possibile

(Red.)

(Red.)

(Red.)

Pno

71

rit.

8va

(Red.)

(Red.)

(Red.)

(Red.)

76 **G** Largo ♩ = 56 *mp* *poco a poco*

S. they say you your daugh - ter and your

Pno *mp*
(2nd.)

80 *al mf* *mp*

S. grand - daugh - ter too will wan - der root - - less with

Pno

83 **H** *mf* *mp* *p* *mf* Melodica (if available)

S. on - ly a pass - port to call home

Pno

(Play only if mezzo soprano is unable to play melody on the melodica.)

87

S.

Pno

f *p*

91

S.

Pno

f *p*

8va

96

S.

Pno

f *p*

8va

3 3 3 7



100

S.

Pno

8

8va

7 7 7 7

f *p*

105 I *espressivo*

S.

Pno

mf $\xrightarrow{5}$ *p*

mp $\xrightarrow{5}$ *p*

5



109

S.

Pno

p

8va

(Do not play final chord if playing ossia staff.)

p $\xrightarrow{3}$ *pp* *p*

3

Tenderly ♩ = 92

3. Don't cry

poco rubato

legato

Piano



S.

6

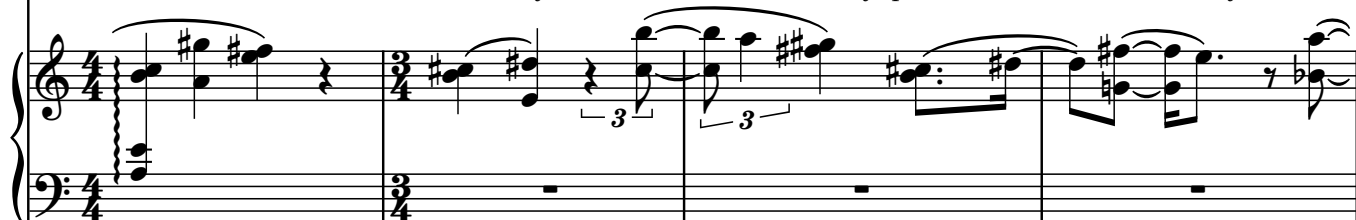
A

mp

Don't cry

mom - my prom - i - ses you

Pno



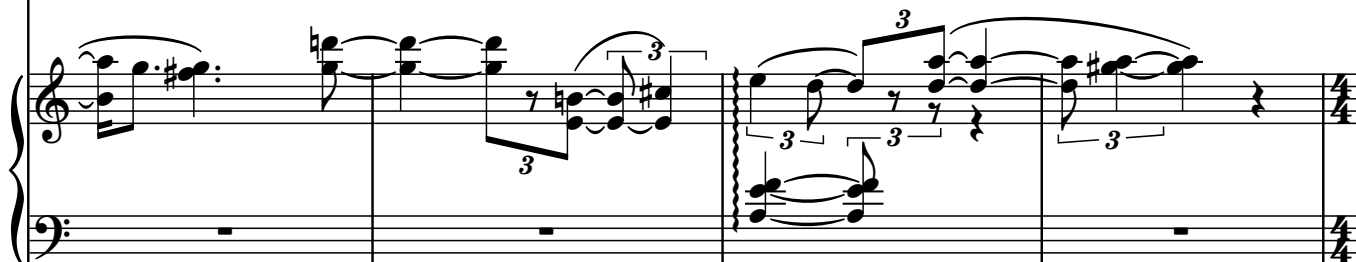
S.

10

no one will come

and de - vour

Pno



S.

14

B Grazioso ♩ = 108

you

no

greed - y

whale of a

com - pan - y

Pno



17

S. shark - ing through po - li - ti - cal seas_ no back - wa - ter

Pno

20

S. bul - ly - ing of busi - niss - es with_ bro - ken mor - als_

Pno

mf

mp

accel.....

24

S. no blind - fold - ed bu - reau - cra - cies_ gon - na push_ this

Pno

p

mp

♩ = 120
29 *mf* C

S. *mo - ther o - cean o - ver the edge*_____

Pno *mf* *p* *Red.*

32 *mp*

S. *no one's drown - ing ba - - by no one's*

Pno *Red.*

35

S. *mov - ing no one's los - ing their home - - land*

Pno *Red.*

38 *mf* *cresc.*

S. no one's gon - na be - come

Pno *mf*

Sost. Sost.

41 *f*

S. a cli - mate change re - fu - gee

Pno

(Sost.)

44 $\text{♩} = 96$ Freely *p* D $\text{♩} = 66$ *mp*

S. or should I say no one else to the

Pno

catch resonance

ffpp

silently depress keys

Red.

Sost.

49 $\text{♩} = \text{♩}$ sempre (unless indicated otherwise)

S. $\text{car - ter - et is - land - ers of pa - pua new gui - nea and to the}$

Pno *pp* *ffpp*

Red. *Red.* *Red.* *Red.*

(Sost.)

52

S. $\text{ta - ro is - land - ers of the sol - o - mon is - lands}$

Pno *pp*

Red. *Red.* *Red.*

(Sost.)

54 **molto rit.** $\text{♩} = 66$

S. $\text{i take this mo - ment to a - pol - i - gize to you}$

Pno *(pp)* *ff*

Red.

E Doppio movimento (Agitato) ♩ = 132

57

S. we are draw - ing

Pno

(Ped.)

ff

60

S. be - - cause ba -

Pno

pp *p*

mf

3

3

62

S. - - by we are

Pno

3

3

64 *f*

S. go - ing to fight

Pno

66 *mf*

S. your mom - my dad - dy bu - bu ji - ma

Pno

Red.

68 *f*

S. your coun - try and pre - si - dent too

Pno

Red.

71 *ff*

S. *we will all fight*

Pno

73 **F** *mf*

S. *e - ven though there are those hid - den be - hind*

Pno

p
Sost. _____

76 *f* *mf*

S. *plat - i - num ti - tles who like to pre*

Pno

mf

79 *f*

S. *f*

- tend that we don't ex - ist

Pno

ff

82 **G** *ff*

S. *ff*

that the marsh - all is - lands ki - ri - ba - ti tu - va - lu

Pno

ff

85 *mf*

S. *mf*

mal - dives and ty - phoon hai - yan in the phil - ip - pines

Pno

f

ff

Sost.

88

S. *mp* (Sost.)

and floods of pak - i - stan al - ger - i - a co - lum -

Pno

91

S. *f*

- bi - a and all the hur - ri - canes earth - quakes

Pno

(Sost.) *mf*

95

S. *ff*

ti - dal - waves did - - n't ex - - -

Pno

H $\text{♩} = 100$
 $\text{♩} \text{---} \text{♩} \text{---} \text{♩} = \text{♩}$

97 *fff*

S. *-ist*

Pno *ff* *p*

8^{ba} *p*

100 *mp* *mf*

S. still there are

Pno *p* *mf*

(8) (p)

104

S. those who there are those who

Pno (8) 8^{ba} (8)

107 *poco* *poco più* ***f***

S. *see us hands reach - ing out*

Pno

(8)

109 $\text{♩} = 132$

S. *fists rais -*

Pno *mp*

111 $\text{♩} = \text{♩}$

S. *- ing up ban - ners un - furl - ing*

Pno *mp* ***f***

114 (♩. = 176) *f* *ff*

S. *me - ga - phones boom - ing*

Pno *f ff*

117 *I f cresc.*

S. *we are*

Pno *mf*

120 *mp f*

S. *ca - noes block - ing coal ships we are the*

Pno *f*

123

S. *ra - di - ance of so - lar vil - li - ges we are the*

Pno *mp* *f*

126

S. *rich clean soil of the farm - er's past*

Pno *mp* *f*

128

S. *we are pe - ti - tions bloom - ing from teen - age fin - ger -*

Pno

J *ff*

130

S. *-tips we are fam - lies bik - ing re -*

Pno

133

S. *-cycl - ing re - us - ing en - gi - neers dream - ing de - sign - ing build - ing*

Pno

136

S. *art - ists paint - ing dan - cing writ - ing and we are*

Pno

139 K *ff*

S. *spread - ing the word and there are thou - sands out in the streets*

Pno

ff

143

S. *march - ing for change hand in hand chant - ing for change*

Pno

L

147 *shout! (not pitched)*

S. *NOW*

Pno

ff

152

S. *f* *3* and they're

Pno *mf* *mp* *p* non legato *mp*

156

S. *3* march - ing for__ you ba - by___ they're march - ing for___

Pno *f* *mf*

159

S. *ff* *3* *3* *3* us be - cause we de - serve to do

Pno *mp*

162 *fff*

S. *more than just sur - - - - - vive we*

Pno *ff*

165

S. *de - serve to thrive*

Pno

167

Pno

4. You'll see

Leggiero ♩. = 120

Piano

mf

Leg.

Pno

mf

Leg.

Pno

mf

Leg.

S.

mf

Leg.

you_

25

S.

are eyes

Pno

(Ped.)

Measure 25: Vocal: G4 (half), A4 (quarter), B4 (quarter), C5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH G3 (half).
Measure 26: Vocal: D5 (quarter), E5 (quarter), F5 (quarter), G5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.
Measure 27: Vocal: G5 (half), F5 (quarter), E5 (quarter), D5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.
Measure 28: Vocal: C5 (half), B4 (quarter), A4 (quarter), G4 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.

29

S.

hea - vy

Pno

(Ped.)

Measure 29: Vocal: whole rest, G4 (quarter), A4 (quarter), B4 (quarter), C5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH G3 (half).
Measure 30: Vocal: D5 (quarter), E5 (quarter), F5 (quarter), G5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.
Measure 31: Vocal: G5 (half), F5 (quarter), E5 (quarter), D5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.
Measure 32: Vocal: C5 (half), B4 (quarter), A4 (quarter), G4 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.

33

S.

with

Pno

(Ped.)

Measure 33: Vocal: whole rest, G4 (quarter), A4 (quarter), B4 (quarter), C5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH G3 (half).
Measure 34: Vocal: D5 (quarter), E5 (quarter), F5 (quarter), G5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.
Measure 35: Vocal: G5 (half), F5 (quarter), E5 (quarter), D5 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.
Measure 36: Vocal: C5 (half), B4 (quarter), A4 (quarter), G4 (half). Piano: RH whole rest, LH whole rest.

37

S.

drow - - - sy weight_____

Pno

(Ped.)

42

S.

so _____

Pno

(Ped.)

46

S.

— just — — — close — — — your eyes

Pno

(Ped.)

51

S.

ba - by

Pno

(Ped.)

55

S.

and sleep in

Pno

(Ped.)

58

S.

peace be - - - cause we

l.h.

Pno

(Ped.)

62

S. won't let you down

Pno

(Ped.)

l.h.

65

S. you'll

Pno

(Ped.)

l.h.

69

A

S. see

Pno

(Ped.)

Pno

72

8va

(Ped.)

Measures 72-73. The right hand plays a melody with an 8va marking. The left hand plays a bass line. A pedal point is indicated at the end of measure 73.

Pno

74

8va

(Ped.)

Measures 74-75. The right hand plays a melody with an 8va marking. The left hand plays a bass line. A pedal point is indicated at the end of measure 75.

Pno

77

8va

(Ped.)

Measures 77-78. The right hand plays a melody with an 8va marking. The left hand plays a bass line. A pedal point is indicated at the end of measure 78.

Pno

79

8va

8va

rit. poco a poco.

(Ped.)

Measures 79-80. The right hand plays a melody with an 8va marking. The left hand plays a bass line. A pedal point is indicated at the end of measure 80. The tempo marking "rit. poco a poco." is present.

81

Pno

8va

(Ped.)

83

Pno

8va

(Ped.)

85

Pno

8va

(Ped.)

87

Pno

8va

rit. poco a poco
♩. = 90

(Ped.)

(8)

89

Pno

(And.)

♩ = 72 **rit.**..... ♩ = 36

(8)

91

Pno

(And.)